

Space shuttle

A partly reusable craft built by the US to send astronauts into space, the shuttle was first launched in April 1981.

Which bit is that?

The shuttle has three main components: the orbiter (the plane part, and the only part that goes into orbit), a huge fuel tank, and two rocket boosters.

Ditch the tanks!

The rocket boosters are released two minutes after launch. They parachute back to Earth and will be used again. The tank is discarded eight minutes after launch, and breaks up in the atmosphere.

The orbiter carries between five and seven crew members.

Main (external) fuel tank



Heat protection

Nearly 25,000 heat-resistant tiles cover the orbiter to protect it from high temperatures on re-entry.

weird or what?

Woodpeckers delayed a space shuttle launch in 1995 by pecking holes in the fuel tank's insulating foam. Plastic owls are now used to frighten other birds away.



The orbiter's engines are used once the orbiter reaches space.

There are two rocket boosters, one on each side. Once lit, the boosters cannot be shut off; they burn until they run out of fuel.